



The SAGE Encyclopedia of Online Education

YouTube

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The innovator in online video proliferation, YouTube has been used by educators since its earliest days. Launched in 2005 by Steve Chen, Chad Hurley, and Jawed Karim, YouTube quickly became the most popular video sharing site, making possible the sharing of millions of videos, produced by businesses, colleges and universities, and individual users alike. It is simple to use and free of charge, making it a useful vehicle both to share video content and to find appropriate content for educational purposes. It is ubiquitous, being the third most visited website on the Internet, behind Facebook and Google. Of course, like any other type of content found on the Internet, there is both high- and low-quality content, and it is up to the user to decide if the content is appropriate and helpful. In the online educational setting, it is typically the course designer, the subject matter expert, or the instructor serving the curatorial function.

YouTube and Education

There are more than 500 university-run YouTube channels, along with countless other educational channels, producing content that is appropriate for both the traditional and the online university classrooms. There is material on nearly every academic subject, including lectures, interviews with scholars and theorists, content created by individual instructors, and more general videos that communicate individual concepts. Sociologist Michael V. Miller (2009) stated, with regard to using online media such as YouTube in the classroom, that the most important function that it can play is in its

capacity to serve as representational applications for key ideas. Whether in the form of a news story, movie clip, interview or documentary, information and illustrations afforded by media are particularly valuable in helping students acquire the initial mental imagery essential for conceptual understanding. (p. 396)

Especially with online education, where the natural visual of the face-to-face classroom experience is absent, the representations of people, places, and ideas contained in YouTube videos can go a long way toward enriching the student experience. Some research has even led to the conclusion that students viewing materials in video clips in a social setting outperformed students attending traditional class lectures. Discussions of the videos among the students led to the construction of meaning, an idea that became the theoretical underpinning of the idea of the “flipped classroom.” Additionally, students can see perspectives other than those given by the lecturer in a traditional class. Like many of the tools of online education, videos watched on YouTube are asynchronous, making it easier for online students to watch them as their schedules allow.

YouTube EDU

YouTube EDU is a program for learners and teachers supported by YouTube for schools and YouTube for teachers. It is YouTube’s corpus of more than 700,000 high-quality educational videos from partners, such as Khan Academy, TED-Ed, and Stanford University. YouTube for teachers helps align core subjects and provides methods and techniques for bringing YouTube into the classrooms, while YouTube for schools facilitates schools to access YouTube content. There are four primary learning segments through which a learner can access high-quality educational content worldwide:

1. Pre-K channels provide content for early childhood.
2. Primary and secondary channels, also known as the K–12 segment, offer content for

- use from preschool to secondary school.
3. Higher education channels include content for colleges and universities.
 4. Lifelong learning content includes the widest range of subjects from museums to linguistics.

The vision of YouTube EDU is to provide a global platform for teaching and learning. The users can discover, create, and share educational videos through YouTube EDU, giving them an opportunity to be watched by a global audience. Thousands of schools around the world can watch the videos uploaded by millions of users. Programs with educational content for primary, secondary, and higher education may be of varying lengths. Creative Commons licenses facilitate the editing, building, and republishing of more than 4 million videos. Channel strategies have three different dimensions—(1) content style, (2) content scope, and (3) programming strategy. The prevalent content style uses two approaches: (1) edutainment, which is a less formal approach for education, and (2) academic, which involves a more formal teaching structure.

Learning with YouTube and YouTube EDU still relies on effective instruction and need to be based on sound educational practices. Any topic can be discussed further when the instructor addresses misconceptions, uses multiple examples and approaches to teach the same topic, and uses visuals to support learning. YouTube EDU videos are watched inside and outside classrooms. Therefore, they must engage the users and grab their attention. A good educational video entices its viewers with thought-provoking questions. It explains what they will learn if they watch the full video, provides a preview of the video, and sets up a compelling example to which the viewer can refer throughout the lesson. Academic channels apply teaching methodology to create effective videos. Employing graphics, transitions, and other packaging enhances the quality of the videos, as do conceptual structure and the highlighting of key conclusions. Traditional lectures become an engaging and effective experience when the creator provides additional information and tips, posing questions and explaining difficult concepts. Long form content is generally divided into shorter videos, including teasers, clips, and trailers to supplement and direct viewers to the full versions.

“Tent-pole” programming increases the number of times a video is viewed. If a user releases his or her video in a timely manner on a high-profile topic that is in the public consciousness, the content will attract and appeal to more viewers. An approach that emphasizes presenting the right content at the right time helps the user build a curriculum experience with a YouTube channel. Curriculum-based videos explain early in the video what part of the curriculum the video covers, indicate whether the viewer should watch another video first, and direct the viewers to the next video in the series. Annotations help build an interactive session between the audience and the member. Videos that are part of a syllabus have numerical notations so that viewers can go directly to them, skipping portions or viewing them sequentially. Playlists generally show a clear path by which the viewer can get from one lecture to the next and help organize the content around the syllabus. The use of an interstitial feature to insert text cards between videos in the playlist that function as introductions or reviews provides a more specific identification of the parts of the video.

YouTube EDU content creators use various optimization strategies, including metadata, thumbnails, and transcriptions and captions. The metadata strategy aligns with the overall channel strategy. Less formal or more formal methods are adopted depending on the curriculum. In addition to key words, tags provide specific questions with reference to the video. Captions and transcriptions are helpful for the students using programs in languages in which they are nonnative speakers. Translations increase the international appeal to the

video.

A good video can be more effective when it invites viewers to interact with the content, by asking questions to which students can respond in comments and having them explore the topic in other videos. In turn, this process helps the creator build new series of videos based on feedbacks, comments, and suggestions. When viewers feel that they are participating in the video rather than just watching it, they enjoy the learning process. Interactive videos talk directly to the viewers and convey the feeling of being in an actual classroom.

Students can now simply submit their class presentations in three steps—(1) creating the video, (2) uploading the video, and (3) discussing the video. YouTube EDU acts as a conduit for this process, so that their teachers and peers can view their presentations as they do in their regular classrooms. The creator can stipulate whether the video is for the entire global audience or for a specific group of people.

Challenges Presented by YouTube in Educational Settings

Although YouTube videos can enhance many classes in both traditional and online educational settings, there are important challenges that must be addressed. Video usage in a classroom may be constrained by copyright issues that the college or university must deal with, although in many cases, permission is required only for commercial use. The use of YouTube videos in courses housed by for-profit online universities raises copyright issues when a video is used in the classroom, although assigning students materials to watch in their homes may sidestep this issue. Student resistance, sometimes as a result of technological issues, also can be a challenge. YouTube has relied heavily on Adobe Flash, which causes problems for some computers and mobile devices, though it is now often using the more accessible HTML5. The quality of the videos can be uneven, necessitating time-consuming curatorial work on the part of the instructor. Finally, and possibly most important, YouTube videos are not always accessible to all populations. For example, YouTube is completely blocked in China, meaning that a quarter of the world's population cannot access the materials. Additionally, in 2007, the U.S. Defense Department banned streaming sites, including YouTube. Such bans mean that colleges and universities that choose to use YouTube content in their courses have to ensure that all their students are able to access the videos.

Conclusion

The availability of so much video on YouTube is an immense educational asset as a content storehouse that may be utilized for educational purposes. However, content quality is crucial while selecting web-based video content. Free video sharing has limitations; for example, content may be inappropriate or inaccurate, and the video quality may be poor. Some instructors find online video terminology difficult to follow.

Individual account holders can promote their profiles and businesses, but educational organizations using YouTube EDU cannot earn direct monetary profit from it. However, this service provides cost savings, convenience, and enhanced teaching–learning process. The Digital Millennium Copyright Act of 1998 protects YouTube; if copyright holders request removal of their videos, then those clips must be removed from the site.

The importance of video as a visual representation can be employed advantageously to show remote places, digital stories, historic film segments, course lectures, and more. Though

many educational institutions still operate using traditional methods and techniques, this is changing rapidly, and YouTube is becoming as ubiquitous in the educational setting as it is in society at large.

See also [Flipped Learning](#); [Social Media](#); [Videoconferencing](#)

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Further Readings

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